A Record of Today, Not a Forecast

A short guide to planning ahead for Dad's care.

Planning ahead for Dad can sound like guessing his future: first this, then that, then somewhere else. One relative has the stages worked out. Another says nothing will ever need to change. Dad, who manages at home with a little help, may be hearing all of it.

This guide describes a plainer way to plan ahead: write down today, and know whom you'd ask if something changed. It explains. It doesn't assess, and it doesn't predict.

Plan for a fresh look, not a fixed path

Start with what the public sources say about forecasting. The National Institute on Aging says it can be difficult to predict how much or what type of care a person might need. The federal Administration for Community Living says the duration and level of long-term care vary from person to person and often change over time. [1] [2]

So a plan laid out as a sequence of stages rests on a guess. What a family can know is smaller and more useful: what Dad's week looks like now, and who you'd go back to if it changed.

Going back is part of planning. The Institute's advice about living at home as you age is to be realistic and plan to revisit the decision as your needs change over time. The CDC says something similar about a family's own care plan: try to update it every year, or more often if the person has a change in health or medicines. [1] [3]

- Write today's page first, and put a date on it.
- Leave the forecast off. “We don't know yet” is an honest line.

Describe the help in plain terms

The Family Caregiver Alliance suggests asking yourself a few questions and writing the answers on a sheet of paper. Its first: what type of help does my loved one need now to live as independently as possible? The examples it gives are everyday ones, among them dressing, bathing, medication management, companionship, housekeeping and transportation. [4]

For each task in Dad's week, the useful note is what he does himself, what he gets a hand with, who helps, and when. Record how often only where you know it or someone on his care team has told you. Otherwise write “not recorded.”

Ask Dad first. The National Institute on Aging says the best way to know what someone needs is to ask them directly. [5]

Then turn what you've seen into questions. “Dad has stopped driving after dark” goes on the page as it is, with a question beside it for his doctor. A family's list is a description. It isn't a formal determination of anything; those come from the professionals who assess him.

Sort what's confirmed from what's still open

Some lines on the page will have come from a professional: a therapist's instruction, something his doctor said about the stairs. Mark those as confirmed, with who said it and when. Everything else is an open question, and that includes whether Dad should have someone with him at particular times. A supervision question is for the people who assess him. The family's part is to write it down.

Two terms help here. The Administration for Community Living's glossary describes personal care as non-skilled help with things like bathing, dressing, eating and moving around, and skilled care as nursing and therapies that usually require a licensed professional such as a nurse, doctor or therapist. The words help you record who provides what today. They don't tell you which Dad needs. [6]

The family's own part goes on the page too. The Family Caregiver Alliance's questions include: what kind of assistance can I provide myself, do I have a job that will affect the amount of care I can provide, and what types of help are my friends and family members willing to provide? [4]

- Write what each person does now and can realistically keep doing. It's a fact about the arrangement, not a verdict on anyone.

Write questions, not a destination

At some point a relative will want to talk about places. On this page that conversation becomes a list of questions: if things changed, what would any arrangement, at home or elsewhere, need to be able to do for Dad? Each one stays a question until a professional who knows him answers it.

We suggest starting from Dad's week and not from the name of a kind of place, because the names tell you less than they seem to. The National Institute on Aging notes that some facilities offer only housing and housekeeping while many also provide personal care, meals and medical services, and that exact arrangements for assisted living vary by facility and by state. [7]

Keep what Dad would need apart from what he'd like, and keep both on the page. The Family Caregiver Alliance says it's useful to think about the values and preferences of your loved one regarding the types of help he or she will accept. [4]

- His preferences go down in his own words, separate from the family's wishes.
- Nothing here needs a place, a provider or a date attached.

What this means for your family

- Planning ahead becomes one dated page: the help Dad gets today, the changes worth a conversation, and the questions you'd ask then.
- Your part is to describe and to date. Forecasting isn't anyone's job in the family.
- Differing opinions about the future can all stay opinions. The page only records what's true now.
- What a change would mean, and what help would fit, is for his doctor, nurse or therapist, or your care consultant, to say.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't explain any condition, say what Dad needs now or will need later, or point to any kind of care or place. The facts come from the sources below. The advice about what to write down is ours.

Ready for the next step?

You know what planning ahead asks of a family: a clear record of today and a way back to the right people. The care interview makes that record complete. It asks about each area of Dad's daily life in turn, the settled ones included, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. National Institute on Aging, What Is Long-Term Care?
2. Administration for Community Living, How Much Care Will You Need?
3. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Steps for Creating and Maintaining a Care Plan
4. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving at Home: A Guide to Community Resources
5. National Institute on Aging, Does an Older Adult in Your Life Need Help?
6. Administration for Community Living, Glossary
7. National Institute on Aging, Long-Term Care Facilities: Assisted Living, Nursing Homes, and Other Residential Care

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From the Family Care Roadmap · Richard Ladson, Certified Medicaid Planner. Draft for review, generated 2026-10-04.